

Australia Daily Brief

Saturday, October 3, 2026

1,944 words · 8 min read

RE: Fiji sets one-question referendum · Greens pledge to scrap AUKUS · Coalition says navy's two biggest warships sidelined · Pacific leader hits NSW coal approval before Fiji pre-COP · Working holiday places cut to 5,000

ASX 200

8,682

+0.20%

AUD/USD

0.6957

-0.74%

NZX 50

13,680

-0.95%

NZD/USD

0.5623

-0.50%

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• TODAY AT A GLANCE

- 1 Fiji's parliament passed a referendum law unanimously and sent the Constitution Amendment Bill 2026 to a joint select committee chaired by Prime Minister Sitiveni Rabuka, which reports back on November 2.
- 2 David Shoebridge has made scrapping AUKUS, blocking weapons for Ukraine, and curtailing the US alliance Greens campaign policy days after taking the leadership.
- 3 A Pacific leader attacked the Minns government's approval of New South Wales's largest coal mine expansion days before pre-COP31 meetings in Tuvalu and Fiji.

• TOP STORIES

PACIFIC-POLITICS

Fiji legislates for its first referendum, one question only

Parliament passed the National Referendum Bill unanimously after midnight on Thursday, giving Fiji a legal framework for a referendum for the first time. Acting Attorney-General and Minister for Justice **Siromi Turaga** said voters would be asked a single question on whether they support the proposed Constitution, and that registered voters overseas may take part. The vote proceeds only if MPs pass the Constitution Amendment Bill 2026 by a two-thirds majority; the bill cleared its second reading 38 votes to five, with nine abstentions, and now sits with a joint select committee for 30 days of consultation. The Elections Office told the government last week it was ready to run both the referendum and the general election.

per Fiji Sun: "Turaga: Referendum will have one question"

AU-POLITICS

Greens set defence red lines: no arms for Ukraine, curtail the US alliance

David Shoebridge believes the Greens can win votes by campaigning to scrap the AUKUS nuclear-powered submarine pact and legalise recreational cannabis, the Sydney Morning Herald reported. The party's defence red lines under its new leader include refusing weapons for Ukraine and curtailing the US alliance. Shoebridge took the leadership days ago and has said the Greens will seek to replace Labor rather than work with it.

per Sydney Morning Herald (Matthew Knott): "New Greens leader: No weapons for Ukraine, curtail the US alliance"

AU-DEFENSE

Coalition demands government 'urgently redress' out-of-service warships

The navy's two largest warships are sidelined in Sydney, The Australian reported, with the Coalition calling on the government to urgently redress the state of the surface fleet. The opposition cast the loss of availability as evidence of a funding crisis in the defence portfolio.

per The Australian: "'Urgently redress': Coalition's call over out-of-service navy ships"

PACIFIC-DIPLOMACY

Pacific leader attacks NSW coal expansion days out from Fiji climate talks

Approval by the Minns government of New South Wales's biggest ever coal mine expansion drew public criticism from a key Pacific leader ahead of next week's UN climate summit in Fiji. The Post-Courier described the intervention as a major headache for Energy Minister **Chris Bowen**, who faces Pacific counterparts at the meeting.

per PNG Post-Courier: "Pacific leaders slam NSW government coal mine decision ahead of UN climate summit"

• OVERNIGHT

AU-FOREIGN-POLICY [US and Australia suspend consular services in Brazil before election](#) · AP

The United States and Australia suspended consular services in Brazil ahead of the country's election, citing security concerns. Bloomberg and the Washington Post carried the same announcement.

PACIFIC-POLITICS [Fiji police find sealing tapes in \\$50m missing cocaine probe](#) · Fiji Sun

Police found tapes believed to have been used to seal cocaine now missing from the Suva High Court exhibit room during a Friday search of a Valelevu home belonging to a former senior judiciary officer and her husband, with more than 20 officers from the Criminal Investigations Department, Forensics and the Dog Unit attending. The officer, one of six persons of interest, is believed to have left the country. Opposition Leader **Inia Seruiratu** said authorities must urgently establish whether any of the *more than \$50 million* of missing cocaine has reached the streets.

AU-POLITICS [Working holiday visa squeeze puts Labor's regional seats at risk, analysts say](#) · ABC News

Third-year working holiday visa places have fallen from 31,000 last year to just over 5,000 under the government's changes, the ABC reported. A political marketing expert told the ABC that key Labor seats in Queensland depend on working holiday staffing and are heavily exposed to the change. Backpackers in Far North Queensland, the country's third-largest foodbowl, are already leaving the region.

AU-FOREIGN-POLICY

[Investigators tie African meth lab network to Sinaloa supply of Australia, NZ](#) · AFP

Investigators say a crystal methamphetamine laboratory uncovered in Africa is one of a network established by the Sinaloa cartel to supply Australia and New Zealand, AFP reported. The finding places an offshore production node inside a supply chain aimed at Australasian markets.

• STAT OF THE DAY

5,000

third-year working holiday visa places, down from 31,000

The cut is reshaping seasonal labour supply in Far North Queensland and, analysts told the ABC, exposes Labor's regional seats.

ABC News

• AUKUS WATCH

PILLARS 1 AND 2 · CSIS

[Australian defence materiel counsellor on industrial-base integration](#)

Jerry McGinn interviewed **Belinda Templeman**, Australia's Minister-Counsellor for Defence Materiel, on the All About the Base podcast about the growing integration of the US and Australian defence industrial bases. The discussion covered AUKUS, critical minerals, co-production, supply chains, and allied industrial resilience.

• PACIFIC WIRE

COOK ISLANDS · COOK ISLANDS NEWS

[Brown takes climate finance and ocean protection to Pacific Pre-COP31](#)

Prime Minister **Mark Brown** travels to Tuvalu and Fiji this week for Pacific Pre-COP31, where he will press for accessible climate finance, ocean protection, and regional resilience projects.

VANUATU · VANUATU DAILY POST

[Indonesia courts Vanuatu beyond medicine and education](#)

Indonesia donated a portable X-ray machine to Vanuatu National Hospital and is seeking ties with Port Vila that run beyond medicine and education, the Vanuatu Daily Post reported. This brief reported on September 30 that Vanuatu renewed its call for a UN human rights visit to West Papua.

VANUATU · VANUATU DAILY POST

[Vanuatu to review two-year earthquake recovery, with public input](#)

Government agencies have begun preparing an After-Action Review of the recovery from the December 17, 2024 Efate-Port Vila earthquake, scheduled for November 30 to December 4. The Council of Ministers declared a 24-month Disaster Recovery Process under the Disaster Recovery and Resilience Act No. 17 of 2024, a period that ends in December 2026. Members of the public will be able to submit their experiences.

FIJI · FIJI SUN

Declared campaign gifts to villages exempted from Fiji bribery law

The Political Parties (Registration, Conduct, Funding and Disclosures) Amendment Bill 2026, passed on Thursday, provides that a gift declared in accordance with the law is not bribery under section 140 of the Electoral Act 2014, where it is given as protocol to obtain permission to enter a village or community group's territory. Declared gifts count toward campaign expenditure limits, and candidates must report donations and spending to the Registrar within 60 days of polling day. The reforms incorporate Multinational Observer Group recommendations.

SAMOA · SAMOA OBSERVER

Samoa weighs user-pay charging for its government EV fleet

The Ministry of Natural Resources and Environment is developing a user-pay system for its electric vehicle charging stations after finding the existing arrangement lacked a sustainable model for cost recovery, monitoring, and expansion. Samoa had received 76 *vehicles* under the Climate Action Pathways for Island Transport project by July 2025, and operates a solar-powered charging station at Friendship Park in Apia. Officials, consultants, and SPREP reviewed business model and payment options in Apia on September 24; no fees or start date have been announced.

PAPUA NEW GUINEA · PNG POST-COURIER

Australia hands literacy resources to PNG school on World Teachers' Day

Australia presented books and literacy resources to Iobuna Kouba Primary School to mark World Teachers' Day, part of its support for early-grade literacy in Papua New Guinea.

VANUATU · VANUATU DAILY POST

TORBA province gains two councillor seats

TORBA Provincial Government Council president **Roy Adams** announced on Motalava that the province has gained two additional provincial councillor seats, East Gaua and East Vanualava.

REGIONAL · SAMOA OBSERVER

Sea Level Rise Declaration gives all UN members a shared position

The UN General Assembly adopted the Sea Level Rise Declaration last month, the first time all member states have agreed a shared approach to rising seas, according to an op-ed published by the Samoa Observer. The text was shaped with Small Island Developing States, Australia, and Cabo Verde as drafters. The piece cites the UK commitment on continuity of statehood made by **Rosie Winterton**, UK Minister for the Indo-Pacific, and support for Vanuatu's campaign for an International Court of Justice advisory opinion on climate change.

FIJI · FIJI SUN

Fiji drafts National Ageing Policy for 2026 to 2035

Minister for Women, Children and Social Protection **Sashi Kiran** said the National Ageing Policy 2026-2035 was developed after consultations with 2,568 *people* across 13 provinces and 37 districts. The policy, prepared with the National Council for Older Persons, goes to Cabinet in October with an implementation plan already drafted.

PAPUA NEW GUINEA · PNG POST-COURIER

Marape commissions 54 police officers

Prime Minister **James Marape** congratulated 54 newly commissioned police officers and challenged them to serve with discipline, integrity, and commitment. This brief reported on September 30 that PNG election security budgets have not been reconciled ahead of the 2027 poll.

• NEW ZEALAND

No significant New Zealand developments in the past 24 hours.

CHINA IN THE PACIFIC

COOK ISLANDS · AMBASSADORIAL TRANSITION · COOK ISLANDS NEWS

Cook Islands farewells Chinese ambassador after five years

Cook Islands High Commissioner to New Zealand **Kairangi Samuela** hosted a farewell luncheon for **Wang Xiaolong**, the outgoing Ambassador of the People's Republic of China to the Cook Islands, at the end of his five-year tenure.

COOK ISLANDS · SEABED MINERALS · COOK ISLANDS NEWS

Seabed authority says US science fellowship confers no control

The Seabed Minerals Authority said an upcoming international science fellowship provides technical support to strengthen local expertise while leaving regulatory control and sovereignty entirely in Cook Islands hands. This brief reported on September 8 that China reaffirmed its backing for Cook Islands seabed work as a US scientist travelled to Rarotonga.

• CANBERRA POLITICS

AU-POLITICS · GUARDIAN AUSTRALIA

Greens deputy leader Hodgins-May profiled as she targets Albanese

Steph Hodgins-May, the new deputy leader of the Greens, left corporate law after visiting Samoa in the wake of the 2009 tsunami that killed her mother, the Guardian reported. Born in Ballarat to a farmer and a school teacher, she is now campaigning against **Anthony Albanese**.

AU-POLITICS · ABC NEWS

Bandt breaks with Shoebridge: work with Labor, do not replace it

Former Greens leader **Adam Bandt**, now chief executive of the Australian Conservation Foundation, told ABC's *Insiders On Background* that working with the government is key to delivering reform, countering **David Shoebridge's** declared aim of replacing Labor. Bandt spoke ahead of his trip to Fiji for the pre-COP31 meeting.

• BUSINESS AND ECONOMY

TRADE-ECONOMY · ABC NEWS

G7 to release 100 million barrels, with Australian pump prices in view

G7 countries agreed to release *100 million barrels* of diesel and crude from reserves over four months and pledged not to impose export restrictions on energy products, after a video conference chaired by French

President **Emmanuel Macron** that followed a conversation with **Donald Trump**. Brent stood at \$102.25 on October 2, down 2.88 percent. The Sydney Morning Herald reported the release is expected to put downward pressure on Australian fuel prices.

TRADE-ECONOMY · ABC NEWS

Firmus float sized at \$7.2 billion, valuing the group at \$43.7 billion

Data centre builder and operator Firmus is expected to raise *\$7.2 billion* in new capital next Friday, which the ABC reports would value the Singapore-based company at \$43.7 billion and make it Australia's second-largest listing after Telstra's privatisation. Blackstone holds close to 7 percent of existing stock and Nvidia slightly more. Co-founder **Oliver Curtis** served a year in prison for conspiracy to commit insider trading.

TRADE-ECONOMY · FIJI SUN

Fiji warns El Nino dry spell will carry into 2027 cane season

Minister for Agriculture, Waterways and Sugar **Tomasi Tunabuna** said farmers harvesting late face challenges maintaining cane productivity next season because El Nino will extend into 2027, slowing crop recovery. He urged growers to maximise tonnage to mills before the end of crushing and said the ministry has a back-up plan if conditions worsen.

TRADE-ECONOMY · FINANCIAL TIMES

FT casts Australian grid storage as a 'postcard from the future'

The Financial Times reports on Australia's big battery build-out, describing the country's grid-scale storage as a postcard from the future for other electricity systems.

• PRIMARY DOCUMENTS

READOUT · AUSTRALIAN MINISTER FOR FOREIGN AFFAIRS

Wong announces inaugural Australia-Japan Leadership Dialogue

Foreign Minister **Penny Wong**'s office released a statement on the inaugural Australia-Japan Leadership Dialogue. No further detail was carried in the release as published.

• UPCOMING

OCT
31

Vanuatu 2027 government scholarship applications close, online only

First round run entirely through the Scholarship Management Information System, a test of Vanuatu's digital service delivery.

OCT
2026

Pacific Pre-COP31 meetings in Tuvalu and Fiji, with the UN climate summit in Fiji

Australian ministers meet Pacific counterparts days after Pacific criticism of the New South Wales coal mine approval.

NOV
2

Fiji joint parliamentary select committee reports on the Constitution Amendment Bill 2026

Determines whether the bill reaches a third reading and whether a constitutional referendum is held at all.

NOV
7

New Zealand general election, advance voting from 26 October

Decides whether the National, ACT and NZ First coalition continues to set New Zealand foreign and defence policy.

• THE WIRE

AU-POLITICS

SYDNEY MORNING HERALD

Hartcher: the government must shift from pleasing the electorate to doing something

Peter Hartcher writes that the world is changing rapidly and the Albanese government must change with it, moving from pleasing the electorate to acting.

SYDNEY MORNING HERALD

Both major parties have failed to sell Australia as an immigration nation

A Sydney Morning Herald column argues neither major party has told the story of Australia as an immigration nation, noting that *51 percent* of Australians are the children of immigrants.

AU-DEFENSE

AUSTRALIAN DEFENCE MAGAZINE

ADM podcast examines LAND 8710, the Army's littoral manoeuvre watercraft

Australian Defence Magazine's podcast looks at LAND 8710, the Army's watercraft programme for littoral manoeuvre capability.

THE AUSTRALIAN

The Australian: age of AI warfare favours attackers and Canberra is exposed

The Australian's Inquirer argues the age of AI warfare favours attackers and that Australia is critically exposed to rapidly advancing AI weapons.

PACIFIC-POLITICS

COOK ISLANDS NEWS

Mana Collective presses sovereignty question before Cook Islands election

A letter from the Mana Collective says the question it put to prospective governments about sovereignty and foreign policy has become more urgent since the 55th Pacific Islands Forum Leaders Meeting in Koror, held from August 30 to September 4.

VANUATU DAILY POST

Vanuatu declares watery diarrhoea outbreak on Santo

The Ministry of Health declared an outbreak after more than 100 cases of acute watery diarrhoea were reported in SANMA province between August 24 and September 20, with four confirmed in the latest week. SANMA is the second province to have a rotavirus outbreak declared this year, after TAFEA in August.

TRADE-ECONOMY

PNG POST-COURIER

K92 Mining changes leadership at PNG's Kainantu gold mine

K92 Mining announced a leadership transition at its Kainantu Gold Mine in Eastern Highlands Province, elevating **John Lewins** to non-executive chair and appointing **David Medilek** chief executive after more than a decade of operations in Papua New Guinea.

CSIS Australia Chair

AUSTRALIA DAILY BRIEF

Washington, D.C.

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